



"This is going to be a real nightmare if we can't get in and out fast. Intelligence says that the Scourge are heading our way and the Shaltari are converging to intercept them. Sounds great right? Wrong. The transmitter is right in the middle of where we predict the battle will ensue." Sergeant Hastor instructed his unit, pointing to a data-slate with images of a map on it.

"Our orders are to enter the building, get the transmitter out and leave before the two forces meet each other."

The Bear APC rushed forwards, the unit inside bouncing in their seats as the APC traversed the craters and pot holes from an earlier assault. Reaching the plaza, the APC stopped, with a hiss the rear hatch opened and the unit filed out. The transmitter had to be removed before the Scourge and Shaltari forces collided.

The unit made good progress taking the transmitter from the building and had begun to move back down when the men noticed that the ground had begun to shake. Hastor cursed - they were too late.



The vibrations were shaking the entire building; Hastor was barely able to keep his footing as he peered out of the window to where a group of Scourge Prowlers were moving through the city. A deafening screech was heard as a green beam pierced the air, slamming into the Scourge lines, demolishing a handful of the walkers.

The vibrations resumed as Hastor's view was filled by a gargantuan mechanised walker, the biggest that Hastor had ever seen, flanked by several smaller Warstriders. The Siegestrider had a bright glowing crest made from yellow crystals. Hastor was amazed, the construct appeared almost primate in appearance, but carried a grace that only the Shaltari possessed. Two cannons the size of a large crane sat either side of the hull of the walker, still faintly glowing green. Jet skimmers and smaller walkers emerged around the towering construct, filling the plaza.

"HQ needs to be alerted about this," Hastor decided. "We, we underestimated the Shaltari, our forces cannot stand up to that monster."

SHALTARI

The Shaltari are an ancient, highly developed species. Their technology is advanced to a level of sophistication rivalled only by its potency. They have traversed the stars for millennia, learned myriad truths, and fought countless wars. Through knowledge, the Shaltari transcend even death itself, perceiving the ebb and flow of time like no other race.

In battle, the Shaltari are fearsome adversaries. Their swiftness is unmatched, their firepower unequalled, their bravery undeniable. The beauty of their constructs belies their true nature; instruments of death, honed to lethal perfection long before humanity learned to throw stones. They are peerless masters of technology.



PHYSIOLOGY

Shaltari are diminutive, standing a little over four feet high, and roughly humanoid, although disproportionately long-limbed. They are covered from head to foot in long, thick spines, the colour of which can be changed at will. Waves of complex patterns are broadcast at bewildering speed, a trait which has been likened to cuttlefish on Earth. Despite this, individuals present a dominant colour for the majority of the time, believed to be linked to complex psychological states.

Shaltari have large, ovoid eyes – always an opaque blue, lacking pupils. Their vision is broadly equivalent to a human's. A Shaltari has no discernible nose or ears, although a small mouth is visible, lined with short, sharp teeth.

They move with a disquieting grace, although they can be faster than humans when pressed. Each movement appears flawlessly coordinated, accomplished with precision and economy. In short, Shaltari seem in perfect control of their bodies, their physical exactitude far beyond mankind's premier martial artists.





THE ENDURING CONSCIOUSNESS

The natural lifespan of a Shaltari is believed to exceed three centuries. The loss of expertise and experience in death was mourned deeply by the early Shaltari, who valued knowledge above all things. This sense of futile loss was eventually banished by their most important technological innovation – consciousness transfer.

Near mortal death, a subject's psyche and memories may be transferred into another physical body. Brain-dead shell bodies are grown specially, allowing the consciousness to endure. This simple summary represents the limits of human understanding of this revered, enigmatic procedure.

In this manner, some Shaltari have lived for millennia, progressing through dozens of bodies. These Elders have vast experience, empowering the Shaltari to expand technologically beyond the scope of all other known races.

An unfortunate side effect is an increasingly acute, pathological fear of death as the aeons pass. The Shaltari have no known religion and view death as simply the end of existence. Having lived for millennia, Elders are terrified of the final death above all things. This makes their actions in battle quite remarkable, a testament to their bravery.

The resting colour of a Shaltari seems to be a good indicator of the age of the consciousness. In general the older the psyche, the paler the spines. Young Shaltari are invariably dark, while ancient Elders are white or even translucent. This colouration apparently has nothing to do with the physical age of the body, rather a reflection of the knowledge and experience of the individual. This is believed to be key to determining hierarchy in a race where learning is held in high esteem, as may have been the case since the earliest days of Shaltari evolution.



FIRSTBORNS

Although seemingly androgynous, there are males and females, though they reproduce incredibly slowly. The gestation period is believed to span 20 years. This sluggish reproduction initially curtailed Shaltari expansion.

With the introduction of consciousness transfer, death due to old age was consigned to history, and numbers increased. Despite this, the population is still relatively small and slow to expand, one of the few true weaknesses of the species.

Death from other causes still occurs, so the population requires replenishment, with new personalities bringing fresh ideas into a society otherwise in danger of stagnating. These are known as Firstborns. Once they have reached adulthood, they enter public life firmly at the bottom of the hierarchy, with everything to prove and little to lose.

WARRIOR VENERATION

Today, the most common way for a Shaltari to meet death is in battle. To the human psyche, it would seem logical that participation in war would be desperately avoided by such a race. This could not be further from the truth, due to the central tenet in Shaltari culture: Warrior Veneration.

While Shaltari value knowledge, they respect martial endeavour beyond all other undertakings. They've fought for their existence

countless times over their millennia as starfarers. As such, their veneration for warriors has reached a zenith.

This deep reverence has produced a dominant, warlike subculture, a two-tier society where those who have never seen battle cannot even be bestowed with a name. The Shaltari believe this basic level of respect can only be achieved by fighting for the race. This attitude extends to dealings with humans – Shaltari ambassadors refuse to address by name those without military experience. The Shaltari abhor the use of drones as dishonourable, beneath contempt. Physically taking to the battlefield has always been the linchpin of taking one's place in society.

Firstborns almost always join the military, to earn respect and advance. They make up the bulk of the infantry, where mortality rates are highest. Firstborns do not yet fear death excessively. They are fiery, remorseless warriors.

Older individuals often remain in the military, regularly taking to the battlefield. Many simply cannot stomach civilian life, yearning for the chaos and symphony of battle. It is believed that a powerful, warlike nature is deeply engrained in Shaltari instincts, explaining their ferociousness in combat.

Fighting Elders are rare but inevitably fulfil command roles. Those that have remained in the military for centuries (or even millennia) are clearly born for nothing but war, peerless commanders, experienced to an unfathomable degree. Their mere survival shows they have tasted victory countless times and seldom known defeat. Captains of capital ships are almost always Elders, something UCMF officers in training are never allowed to forget.

THE TRIBES

The Shaltari have come to embrace the concept of strength through diversity, struggle and competition. Since they are accustomed to being the most advanced, powerful race in their spheres of influence, the only viable source for contest is other Shaltari.

Through the ages, nuances have developed between disparate groups, resulting in clear divisions. These are lauded by all Shaltari as a driving force for development, invention and improvement against stagnation. These groups vary chiefly in attitudes and culture. Individuals often gravitate toward a group with similar opinions to their own, ensuring a healthy genetic mix.

These differences often lead to disagreements and occasionally, open warfare. Battles are often kept small scale, pursued only until honour is satisfied. Such Honour Feuds are respected and even praised as necessary for the maintenance and furthering of strength, since they know of no greater opponents than themselves. Apparently, conflict has been a force for dynamism and striving for betterment. Many believe it keeps this functionally immortal race from stagnating into languid repose, content with its superiority in the universe.

Humans refer to these distinct, opposing blocks as Tribes, a simple term used by early Shaltari ambassadors. Tribes were assigned designations corresponding to early indigenous Earth nations

and cultures, a practice continued by the UCM. These are normally allocated randomly and do not indicate any similarity between the Tribe and its original namesake. Ancient names such as Apache, Inuit, Amazon and Inca are in common usage once again, although now with very different connotations.

Recent observations reveal that greater Shaltari power blocks are emerging, perhaps in response to the Reconquest. Most notably, a large faction including the Apache, Masai, Aztecs, Comanche, Amazons, Zulus and Inuit are in conflict with a smaller collective including the Mongols, Cherokee, Icini and Tlaxcallan. Their opposition goes beyond Honour Feuds, illustrating a profound difference of opinion. All-out Shaltari vs Shaltari warfare is rare but now seems inevitable as these groups weave actions and counter-strokes around each other in an escalating dance of diplomacy and skirmish.

Most notably, the especially warlike Mongols have led the smaller collective in an all-out effort to capture the Cradle World of Aaru. It seems they have almost succeeded in this. While the larger collective has not yet moved against them in this theatre, they have been seen in armed conflict elsewhere. The larger collective, led by the Apache, have been largely focused on disrupting and influencing the Reconquest to their shadowy ends.



HOMEWORLDS

The Shaltari are fiercely protective of their mysterious homeworlds. Should another race stumble across one, they are annihilated, thus preventing any return visits. As such, almost nothing is known about the Shaltari homeworlds, save that they are well distributed throughout the galaxy.

COMMUNICATIONS AND DIPLOMACY

Mankind has had diplomatic relations with the Shaltari since 2342, the early days of human galactic exploration. Indeed, it was a Shaltari Tribe who made first contact, guiding mankind to the Cradle Worlds. The fact that this was apparently done only to secure humanity as an ally against another Shaltari Tribe has characterised subsequent relations. Shaltari and humans have made alliances for mutual self-interest, but balk at shedding blood for the other. As such, the history of human-Shaltari interaction has been a morass of alliances, power struggles and double-dealings.

The Shaltari language is utterly impossible for humans to replicate. A vast vocal range, coupled with visual nuances from colour changes make it quite incomprehensible. As very few Shaltari "words" can even be vocalised by humans, any communication is conducted in human languages, in which the Shaltari are fluent.

The Shaltari share information sparingly, and they are always in control. This makes intelligence gathering challenging, contributing to human ignorance. With little understanding of Shaltari technology and a poor grasp of the language, most alien individuals and constructs are given crude, human designations, sometimes by the Shaltari themselves. This custom originated after an Elder introduced himself as Ramses, since his real name would be impossible for a human to articulate. The convention of using ancient names is practical, since they are no longer in common usage and thus easily distinguishable as Shaltari.

Conflict between Shaltari and humans occurs frequently. Certain tribes have an undisguised contempt for mankind and will take to the battlefield with the slightest provocation. Other tribes attack seemingly at random, guided by various shadowy motives.

Relations with the PHR have so far followed similar lines. In an early development, the PHR allied itself with Tribes typically in conflict with the UCM, although these alliances quickly broke down. It seems probable that one side duped or misled the other – unsurprising, given the famous duplicity of both factions. More importantly, the motives behind such dealings are unknown. That most were initiated by the PHR is disquieting in the extreme.





ARCHITECTS OF FATE

In a stunning twist, the Scourge recently communicated with the UCM for the first (and so far only) time. In an admittedly contempt-filled conversation, the Scourge accused the Shaltari of engineering the entire war. Apparently mankind was considered a prolific, expanding species, both a threat and potential foil to the Scourge. In seeding the Cradle Worlds with humans then subtly redirecting Scourge Seeds, the Shaltari deliberately unleashed war, hoping both species would wipe each other out, thus ridding the Galaxy of two of the Shaltari's most numerous rivals.

While this failed initially, with mankind weakened by the unexpected Warning of the White Sphere, the Shaltari allegedly discreetly aided mankind to gain strength enough to take on the Scourge. If this is true, then the goal must surely be slow death by war of both species. This would explain much of the Shaltari's actions in the conflict so far, since they frequently prevent either side from winning outright victories, perpetuating conflict.

However, this information was received from the Scourge, the greatest blight ever to afflict humanity and undoubtedly its absolute enemy. In many ways, this potential truth changes nothing, since mankind's full hatred is directed against the Scourge until every last one is slain. If that is ever achieved, the UCM may turn its righteous fury against the Shaltari, should this heinous allegation prove true.

ARMIES OF THE TRIBES

Shaltari ground forces are famous for an esoteric assortment of war machines, from towering Dragon Behemoths, to three-legged Warstriders to nimble grav-tanks. All are highly distinctive, encrusted with unknowably complex technological adornments. They are equipped with the most advanced weaponry known to man.

The Shaltari have been almost impossible to bring to full scale pitched battle. Most of their engagements have been isolated, surgical strikes, sudden attack and lightning withdrawal being their preferred method of engagement. Utilising their unique teleportation systems, ground forces can be re-routed and plucked from the battlefield with blinding speed, making it almost impossible for an opponent to deliver a strategic-level blow to the capricious aliens.

THE TRIBAL FLEETS

Unlike the UCM, PHR and Scourge, the Shaltari are far from a united race. Its tribal, martial culture results in routine internecine conflict and void combat is no exception. Shaltari vs Shaltari naval duels are apparently a terrible, breathtaking sight. Such combat ensures that every Shaltari ship is a veteran of countless honour battles, sometimes stretching back centuries.

Each tribe operates its own fleet, the largest being a system-level threat, not including any vessels retained on the tribe's unknown homeworlds. In general though, Shaltari naval strength has been a minor numerical factor thus far - the unpredictable aliens are yet to give battle en-mass. Most hope they simply cannot afford to, given their low population and desire to live into the millennia.



SHALTARI GROUND FORCES

Shaltari ground forces feature a range of technologies so advanced they border on magic in appearance. Their advanced nature means they take to the field of battle in a very different way to other – more conventional – armies.

A central pillar of Shaltari strategy revolves around their teleportation gates. These bewildering feats of technology allow troops to be deployed, rerouted and extracted instantaneously, without putting lives at risk during transit. Their tactical manoeuvres are therefore quite unlike those of other races, making them slippery, formidable adversaries.

An entire army could theoretically deploy from a single teleportation gate (the Shaltari equivalent of dropships). Units can also be transferred between positions through the use of multiple gates, since troops can only materialise in the direct vicinity of a gate. Gates feature a ring of focusing devices and a central core, similar in appearance to a cut gemstone.

An orbiting mothership physically holds units until they're needed, removing risks associated with transporting troops. The mothership provides the power behind this technology - teleport gates merely act as fulcrums, reducing power requirements to manageable levels. It's understood that when troops are rerouted on the ground, they still transfer via the mothership. The actual mechanics are a complete mystery to human science, well behind such dazzling advancements.

There are various sizes of teleportation gates, ranging from vehicles no larger than a standard battle tank, all the way up to the heavy Voidgates orbiting planets. Each works together in unison, allowing thousands of troops to be relocated around battlefields at no more than a moment's notice, the larger gates acting as re-routing points to the smaller ones, creating an entire network. Disabling or destroying this network is therefore a key objective for the Shaltari's enemies – without the gates, their troops are unable to be deployed, and they lose much of their strategic advantage.

For a unit to be teleport-capable, it requires a complex, embedded web of locator systems. This represents one of the few limitations of Shaltari teleportation technology, as only constructs completely encased in such a web can be accurately transferred.

Shaltari vehicles are highly distinctive, famous for their geometric complexity and exquisite splendour. Many liken their appearance to jewellery, though this masks their true nature

as beautifully engineered killing machines. It is understood that virtually every apparently ornamental feature has a real, if enigmatic, function. Shaltari vehicles are often brightly coloured to indicate their alignment to a particular Tribe. This practice relates to Shaltari notions of martial honour, where concealment is regarded as cowardly and dishonourable.

In any case, camouflage is primitive protection compared to the combination of lighting speed and peerless shielding they exhibit. Their all-encompassing energy shields are easily the most advanced and effective examples of such technology yet witnessed. They provide additional protection at all ranges from all types of attack, even by directed energy weapons. The power of these shields can also be boosted by certain specialised units, such as the Dreamsnare. The powerful shields mean that Shaltari vehicles rely more on them than regular armour, and normally when their energy shields are breached, the thinness of this armour makes them relatively fragile.

Shaltari gunnery is rightly feared, being the most advanced yet encountered by mankind. A wide array of lethal devices can bring shattering firepower to bear from afar.

Gauss weapons form the core of Shaltari anti-armour firepower. While superficially similar to UCM railguns, they accelerate a thin dart to a far higher velocity. The darts feature pristine, nano-engineered surfaces to reduce air friction and are not followed by a tell-tale trail of ignited air. Tales are rife of destroyed vehicles with tiny entry cavities and gaping, twisted exit gashes.

Microwave Weapons are used to exterminate enemy infantry. Their beams of high energy microwaves cause blood to boil and skin to cook in a matter of seconds. This is undoubtedly a horrible way to die. Large versions are powerful enough to melt the toughest of vehicles to molten slag, and handheld versions exist, often paired with energy swords for room clearance.

Shaltari weapons are often esoteric in the extreme, such technology a bizarre experience for UCM troops. Gravatic Magnifiers deliver crushing force to anything with mass. The heavier the target, the more devastating the effect. By creating a localised area of high gravity, a target effectively crushes itself under its own weight. The Disruption Cannon meanwhile projects a region of unstable dimensionality, inducing a range of contortion and warping effects on anything caught in the maelstrom. The results are uniquely horrific – bizarrely twisted vehicle hulls, stretched objects and flensed corpses are left in its wake. This weapon effects a wide area, growing in relation to the closeness of the target.



GRAV-TANKS

Shaltari Grav-Tanks are somewhat slower than Scourge equivalents, but like most Shaltari vehicles they feature advanced passive countermeasures, as well as other advantages. The main structures associated with the anti-grav drives are prominent, paddle-like features, especially prevalent on Shaltari aircraft. These remarkable drives also provide impulse to move the vehicle at high speeds with ridiculous manoeuvrability. All this is achieved in complete, eerie silence.

Their standard grav-tank – the Tomahawk – carries a Gauss Cannon, giving it the range of a UCM Sabre and the mobility of a Scourge Hunter. The Kukri AA tank shares the same chassis, its ion cannons offering blistering rates of fire against aircraft.

The Shaltari also employ a light grav-tank chassis, the Yari. The Yari is one of the fastest ground vehicles encountered anywhere, a superlative scout unit, coming with various load-outs for different roles.

Chief among Shaltari grav-tanks though is the super-heavy chassis, one of the largest anti-grav armoured vehicles yet seen. The most common variant is the Caiman, armed with the formidable Gauss Triad, a massive weapon requiring a turret almost as big as the chassis! This provides excellent range which – coupled with grav-tank's speed – makes it a slippery target. The Crocodile and Gharial are variants of the super-heavy chassis, bringing with them incredible tank destroying capabilities, and brutal, close up killing and command abilities respectively.

STRIDERS

Shaltari armies are justly famous for their Warstriders: 3-legged towering war machines several stories high. Although their legs make contact with the ground, their movements are grav-assisted, lending them a disquieting grace as they bestride the battlefield. The Jaguar is most commonly seen, offering a rare and balanced combination of anti-tank and anti-air capability equivalent to that of three main battle tanks. The Coyote is a command variant, dispensing with the AA weapon in favour of an ejectable command pod.

The Ocelot replaces all these weapon systems with a single Particle Cannon, offering near-infinite range and power enough to overload all known countermeasures at the expense of mobility. Based on the same premise, two specialist versions exist: the superlative anti-air Panther and the microwave weapon-bearing Leopard.

Perhaps the strangest Warstrider is the Dreamsnare. Like its smaller cousin the Yari-C, this walker can boost the performance of the shields of other Shaltari units nearby. These are often deployed at the centre of groups of Warstriders, creating a surprisingly tough core to any force.

Battlestriders are effectively smaller versions of Warstriders. Still 3-legged, they can also use their superior mobility and anti-grav assistors to climb the outside of buildings, attaining a superior vantage. The Birdeater is essentially equivalent to the Kukri grav-tank in main armament, although it also mounts a small but effective laser. The Tarantula is more unusual, in that it features a Gravity Cannon – a weapon increasingly effective the larger the target is.



WARSPIRES

These are unusual constructs in that they cannot move under their own power. However, given Shaltari teleport gate technology, they can be surprisingly mobile. Towering higher than even a Warstrider, these imposing edifices are potent threats. The Totem offers lightning-fast anti-tank capability, while also being a danger to passing aircraft. The Obelisk is a potentially more powerful variant, featuring miniature versions of the Ion Storm Generators of Shaltari starships, although it must focus on either anti-tank or anti-air fire.

INFANTRY

Regular Shaltari infantry – known as Braves – are formidable opponents. Shaltari overcome their diminutive stature by wearing lithe, armoured exoskeletons over eight feet in height, known as Warsuits. Their amazing agility is often disquieting to human observers, given their size. They also feature a teleport web, so can be transferred where needed without risk in transit.

The Warsuit greatly enhances the user's strength, empowering Braves to carry devastating small-arms, such as the Gauss Rifle and Discus Launcher. They also feature miniaturised active countermeasure systems, greatly reducing the effective range of enemy

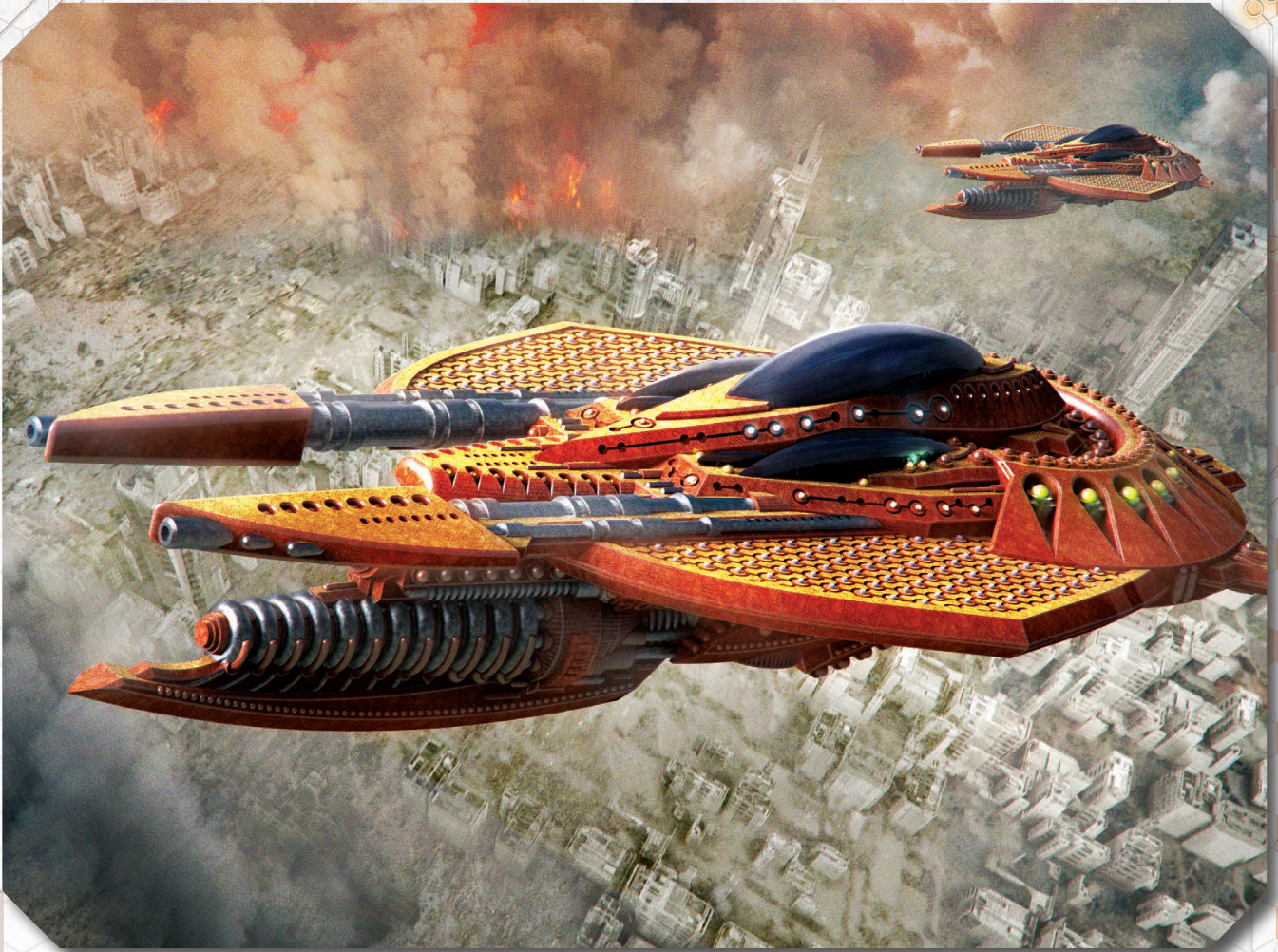
small-arms fire. This combination grants the standard Shaltari soldier the kind of power which human infantry grunts can only dream of. This is often essential, since Braves are almost always outnumbered.

When equipped for close-combat, the risk to the user increases. Such troops are known as Firstborns, since they are usually crewed by young, hothead Shaltari on their first natural life.

Larger variants also exist, such as the Heavy Warsuits employed by the Samurai and Ronin. These are too large to enter most structures but powerful and well protected enough to bstride the open battlefield with some degree of protection.

Being a numerically challenged race, the Shaltari have often tried to recruit other species into their ranks. They even tried this with humanity initially, though their advances were soundly rejected. Today, the enthusiastic (if subservient) Pungari are the most commonly encountered auxiliaries. While it might be unfair to call them a slave race, they certainly revere their Shaltari superiors. What Pungari lack in quality they make up for in numbers. Armed with Shaltari weaponry, they are more of a threat than they might appear.





GATES

Gates are the nexus points for Shaltari teleportation technology and the linchpin around which their entire, highly erratic mode of fighting is based. Equivalent to the medium dropships of more primitive races, the Eden is the most commonly encountered. Its larger cousin, the Gaia is equivalent to a heavy dropship while the Spirit is akin to a light dropship. All Shaltari gates are unarmed, although other offensive units sometimes offer some Gate capacity. All Gates do feature the unusual side-effect of energising the air around them, making their immediate vicinity dangerous airspace for enemy fliers.

A ground variant is also commonplace – the Haven. This grav-tank fulfils the same role as the APCs of other races, and is also unarmed.

AIRCRAFT

The Thunderbird is the most common Shaltari gunship, occupying a medium-range anti-tank role through the use of a short-barrelled Gauss Cannon. The Firebird is a more aggressive variant; with less range, this aerial predator is particularly deadly to large vehicles.

Far larger airborne offensive units also exist, such as the formidable Firedrake. This heavy dropship-sized beast is armed primarily with a Disruption Cannon, but also features a tail-mounted twin Microwave Cannon. The Firedrake also boasts the Gate capacity of an Eden, allowing it to bring in its own ground support. A variant – the Frostdrake – dispenses with this ability in favour of more firepower, adding a Heavy Grav-Cannon and a command deck.

The most common fighter in the Shaltari arsenal is the Warspear. Heavier than the UCM's Archangel and the Scourge's Corsair, this flexible aircraft is equally adept at anti-tank ground attack and also interceptor missions. A variant exists, known as the Khopesh, which replaces the Warspear's Gauss Cannon with a Heavy Bio Atomiser, allowing it to strike unseen at troops inside structures, with horrific but effective results.



BEHEMOTHS

Shaltari Behemoths are enormous, hyper-advanced gods of the battlefield. They bear some resemblance to other Shaltari walker constructs, though they dwarf them. Given their size, they mount some of the most formidable weaponry seen on surface battlefields anywhere in the Reconquest.

The existence of these giants was unknown until recently. The first sightings were made by Resistance groups on the Cradle World of Aaru, where since early 2672 the aliens were making a concerted effort to wrest the world from the clutches of the Scourge. Initially, reports of outlandish machines as tall as tower blocks were dismissed as the ramblings of terrified grunts, until imagery came back. It seemed unlikely to the UCM that such well developed, effective designs were new to the Shaltari, leading to the conclusion that they had simply been kept back for the largest engagements. This seems to be bearing out on Earth so far, where these avatars of destruction are being reported with increasing frequency in the South American theatre, where the Shaltari are most active.

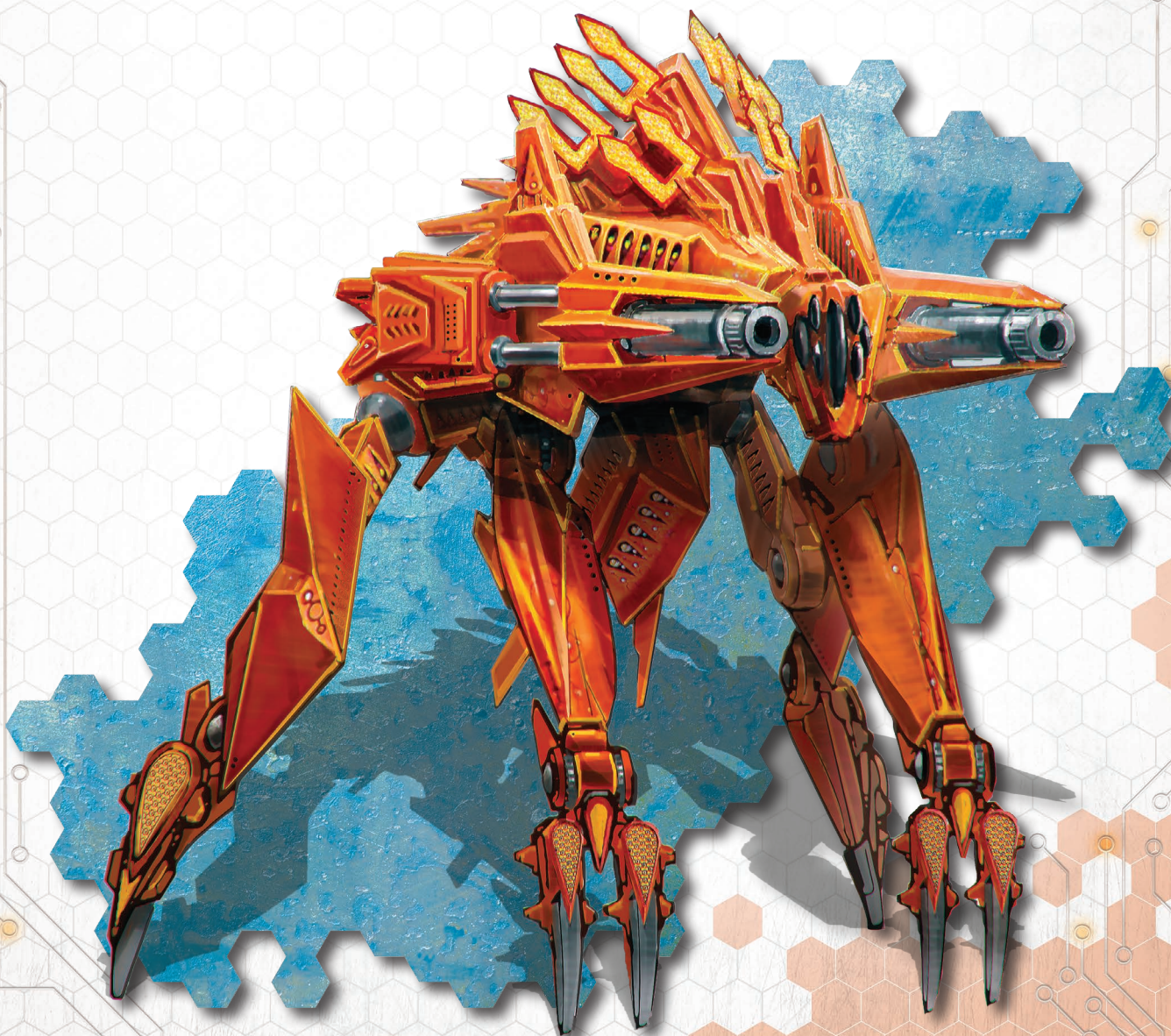
SIEGESTRIDERS

Several times larger than their more common cousins the Warstriders, Siegestriders were dubbed for their ability to clamber over or through the tallest defences. The most well-known forms are quadruped, although more accurately they have two legs and two arms. Though this configuration is superficially similar to that of an old Earth primate, these are far more graceful in build and movement. Like most Shaltari walkers, they are grav-assisted, making such fluid motion possible for something so large. These constructs are known to have a crew of two – invariably an Elder and a co-pilot, strangely one who is often a Firstborn. The reasoning for this is understood that the Elder brings experience and wisdom, and the Firstborn a hot-headed attitude that veers towards recklessness. Combined, both viewpoints are valid, providing extremely unpredictable battlefield roles for the Siegestriders.

Both known variants feature a large “crest” of energised fins known as the Lightning Crown. Though not immediately obvious, this is in fact an unusual weapons system, with two fire modes. The first can unleash coruscating waves of electrical energy, particularly effective against swarms of conventional vehicles, though mercifully short-ranged. The second directs this energy skywards, to down multiple aircraft foolhardy enough to get close. Two variants have so far been identified, distinguished by their arm-mounted primary armaments.

The Tiger carries a pair of Disintegrators – battlefield versions of the type of armament common on Shaltari starships. These weapons transfer huge amounts of energy to a very small area in crackling, split-second bursts. This causes devastating atomic effects, releasing further energies into the target. The appearance is of an explosive detonation that leaves an atomised, gaping hole behind. These weapons are best employed against other Behemoths, where no amount of armour is proof against such power.

The Lion variant carries possibly the most unusual weapon seen on the battlefields of the 27th century: the Transmatter Beam. It actually has two functions, the first being non-offensive in nature. It can make use of the teleportation web technology built into friendly constructs to de-materialise and re-materialize these units anywhere in line of sight, even if they are far from a Gate. The second, weaponised function is the result of firing such a beam at something without tapping into teleport web technology. The target de-materialises all the same as Shaltari constructs – it just reforms as a disparate cloud of constituent atoms in the general area, leaving neat, circular holes behind. The fact that this happens in complete silence is just that much more disturbing. Luckily for enemy forces, the power drain of remote teleportation is so vast that anything smaller than a Behemoth is unlikely to be able to make use of it outside of the gate structures.



DRAGONS

The largest Shaltari Behemoths have been given the designation Dragon, a suitable name for these colossal killing machines. These are unique among Behemoths for a number of reasons. Firstly, instead of a torso-like hull, Dragons feature an elongated, segmented body which is fully articulated, allowing it to weave and wind its way through the battlefield. Given its size, it can get through remarkably small spaces and attain a very low profile, avoiding enemy fire. Particularly mesmerising and otherworldly to watch is the way it moves: with sinuously grace, completely at odds with its massive size. This is primarily due to the fact that it's grav-assisted, so never has to bear its full weight. This ability allows it to traverse over large obstacles in apparent defiance of physics, and arrest its decent when materialised high above the battlefield by a Voidgate starship.

When it prepares to fire, it generally rears up to the full, imposing height of a tower block, over twice as tall as any other known Behemoth. Dragons have eighteen legs, sixteen small arms and six large arms, the latter ending in massive Gauss Destroyers: giant, Behemoth-killing versions of those carried by Warstriders. The head might be considered a weakness, were it not so well shielded. This crucial area contains the crew of three, invariably led by an esteemed Elder. Indeed, like most Behemoths, these tend to be the command chariots of the most illustrious of fighting leaders.

The two distinct classes of Dragon observed so far may be distinguished by their primary, head-mounted weapons.

The Celestial-Dragon carries one of the largest energy weapons seen on battlefields: the Super Particle Triad. This is a triple-barrelled, enormous version of the weapon carried by the far more common Ocelot Warstrider. This offers massive range and peerless armour-penetrating capability. Nothing is ever truly safe from such a weapon. This primary armament is complimented by a pair of tank-sized laser "fangs", which in combination make it one of the most effective means of destroying another Behemoth from a great distance.

The second variant is the Earth-Dragon. This Behemoth carries the Super Disruption Cannon as its primary armament – a giant version of the Firedrake's main gun. This causes extreme dimensional distortion over a wide area, twisting, shearing and shattering all it touches. Its potency only increases with proximity to the target, making the Earth Dragon more suitable for aggressive commanders. Its secondary head armament is a pair of Super Bio-Atomisers: truly terrifying weapons that can empty structures of whole squads of infantry after mere seconds of indescribable agony.

